

CHECK MATE Vaishali at the 2026 Candidates tournament in Cyprus, Mar. 30

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Vaishali Rameshbabu, the come-back-from-behind winner at the 2026 Candidates Chess tournament, becomes only the second Indian woman to earn the right to compete for the world championship crown

By SUHANI SINGH

Chess entered the Rameshbabu household in Chennai with a simple aim: wean their six-year-old daughter, Vaishali, off television. But little did he and wife Nagalakshmi know that not only would their little girl take to the game but that even her younger brother Praggnanandhaa would follow suit, and the siblings would go on to create history as the first brother-sister duo to become grandmasters (GMs). Last week, Vaishali Rameshbabu, 24, added another jewel to her crown by winning the Candidates tournament, earning her a shot at challenging five-time world champion Ju Wenjun for the title. If Vaishali outwits the Chinese legend, she will enter the history books as the first Indian woman to become world champion.